

Cold Days In Devil Country

Seven Devils Mountains, Hells Canyon Wilderness, Idaho

September 4th to 6th, 2010



Back on July 3rd I stayed a weekend out in Boise with the intention of backpacking into the Seven Devil's area of Hell's Canyon with Kim. After a rather large amount of rock gave way underneath me I ended up taking a bad enough fall I broke my tailbone.

This was annoying for several reasons. First I wasn't able to sit down for three or four weeks without rather excruciating pain. Second I had to cancel two trips and actually stay indoors for those weekends doing almost nothing. And last and most important I had to turn around and missed some peaks. I really dislike not getting my peaks.

That was supposed to be the last free weekend of my contract out here in Boise but (surprise surprise) I was extended for the Nth time. This opened up Labor Day weekend which was as of yet unclaimed by other trips.

After throwing out open invitations to the usual crowd I had no takers due to the extra hassle of having to fly out to Boise. Undeterred I was all set to do the trip solo when Tricia Clay, a rock climber and former guide whom I had met a few weeks prior during the 2010 Sierra Challenge, signed on with a rather admirable enthusiasm.

This involved her leaving directly after a class in Joshua Tree California on Friday, jumping on a plane to Boise, arriving at 8 pm, and then the two of us driving several hours to the Windy Saddle trailhead. We'd then spend the next three days running around the wilderness before coming out Monday night so she could take the first flight out Tuesday morning arriving back in town just in time to attend another class. Sounds like one of my weekends!

So after an almost unbearable 5 whole days of work after my Dragon and Gould trip I picked Tricia up at the Boise airport and we started north bound for Riggins and the 17 mile dirt road leading to the trailhead.

Sometime after midnight we pulled in to the rather crowded Windy Saddle and found a small pullout in the campground loop to throw out our sleeping pads. The temperature was quite mellow and the sky was absolutely clear.

We lay out watching the stars for a bit and noticed an odd flashing almost like someone was taking a picture out of sight. Tricia supposed it was heat lighting in the distance. I chose to believe it was aliens or northern Idahoan militias sacrificing Californians in the atmosphere but either way.

Eventually we both fell asleep.

Day1: Hiking In And The Devil's Throne

The nice thing about this trip was we never got up super early but we still made everything in plenty of time. After the previous two weeks of waking up pre-dawn to painfully cold winds this was a welcome improvement.



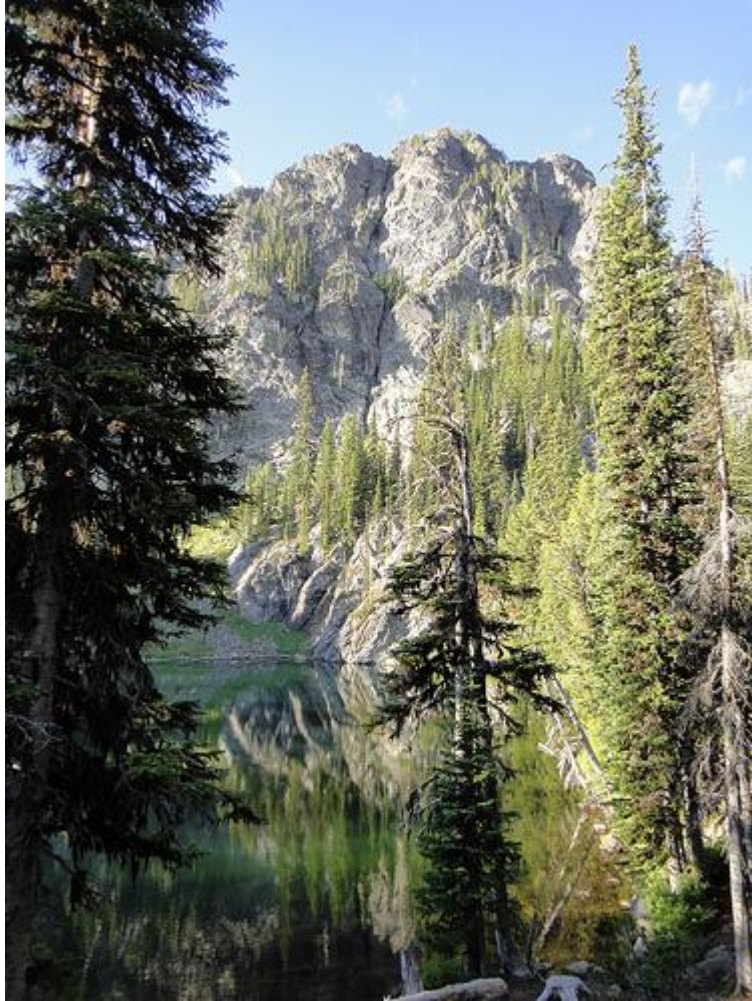
The sky was beautiful in the morning with a few scattered clouds but nothing that looked too serious.



As became the tradition each morning we woke up and both made our coffee. In addition to all around awesomeness Tricia obviously has her priorities straight.



We left Windy Saddle around 7:45 am and set up a use trail unofficially known as the High or Goat Trail. It allows you to reach Sheep Lake in about a mile and a half instead of taking the usual 9 mile backpacking trail. It's a bit steep and indistinct in places but that wasn't a big deal considering our hiking plans for the weekend.



The weather was just about perfect.



We passed the place where I'd taken the fall a few months ago and I resisted the urge to climb it just to prove I could without breaking my butt in half.



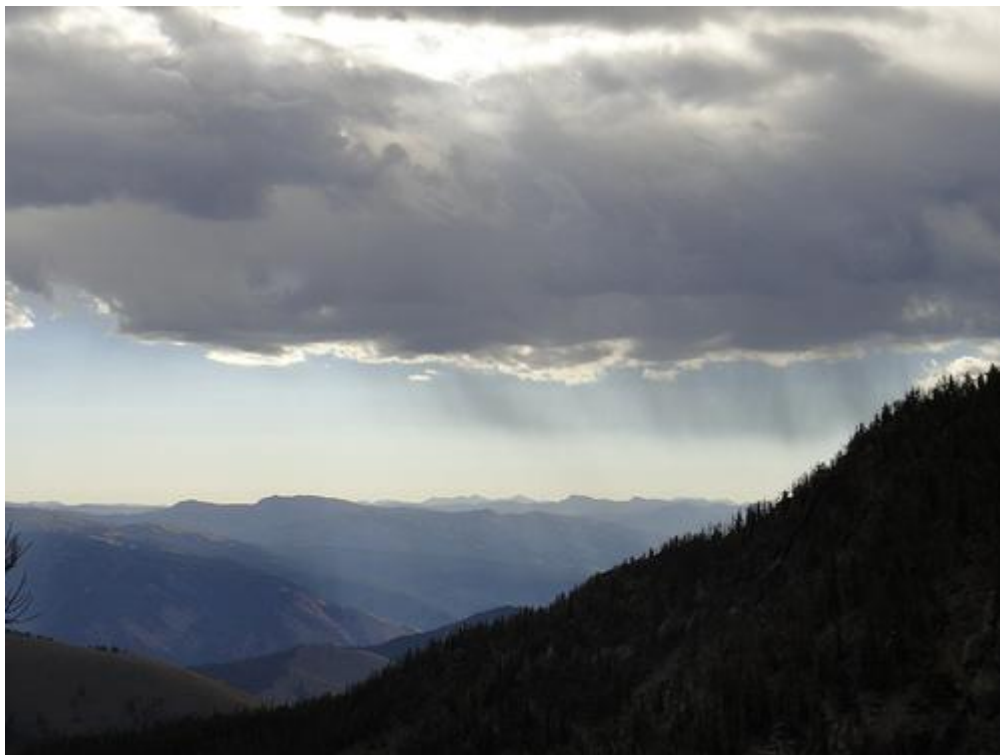
This time the snow which had previously kept me off the main path was gone leaving us a steep but serviceable climb to the top of the initial ridge.



From there things were a bit less distinct.



We saw some rain in the distance above another range but our area was rather pleasant.



We hopped over the last ridge and descended a steep and loose slope to Sheep Lake where we would be base camping for the next two nights.



There were a number of people camped below on the East side of Sheep Lake so we traversed around and found a rather nice spot to the south west directly under the chute we'd be climbing to reach the Seven Devil's crest.



We had neighbors in the campsite next to us but they left also immediately. We didn't even smell at this point! (Much)



It was noon by the time we set up camp and were ready to leave. The climb from camp to the saddle on the Seven Devils crest between He Devil and She Devil was steep and filled with somewhat loose rock which was an annoyance to climb. Nevertheless we ended up climbing this each day in order to reach our peaks and it got old quickly. Still, it turns out it was actually better than the next chute over that we tried Monday.



The main goal of the day was a rather striking peak in the distance called Devil's Throne. While not the highest in the area the fact it stood off by itself made it pretty much the most dominant. It was also the furthest away from camp of anything we'd do that weekend. A good start to the weekend!

We had to descend the far side of the crest into a bowl and headed for a rather non-descript peak that had for some reason been named Belial.

Actually, according to Wikipedia:

"The [etymology](#) of the word is uncertain, but is most commonly translated as "without worth".^[1]"

That's about right.

As we passed a rather nondescript puddle in the bowl it started to rain. At first just a few drops and then it started getting harder.



Of course as soon as we stopped and put on our rain gear it stopped almost immediately.



As we climbed the saddle to the north of Belial we ran into two locals who were convinced they were climbing She Devil. They took a bit of convincing, waiving a GPS at me and claiming they knew exactly where they were, but I pulled out my topo map and eventually set them straight.

Up top we found a young couple who was also a bit confused about which peak was which. More map instruction ensued.



Belial itself was rather unremarkable other than giving us a good look at the Throne.



This was the one peak the entire weekend we actually had company on so I took advantage and asked them to grab a quick summit photo. The peak in the background is Devil's Throne.

From Belial we followed a ridge to the south for a bit crossing some rather loose chutes.



Jumping over another ridge we climbed a cirque climbing south then west to gain the ridge south of Throne.



From there we had some easy rocks to scramble over as we approached our summit.





Victory! The saddle between the two peaks to the right in the background was what we had crossed from camp.

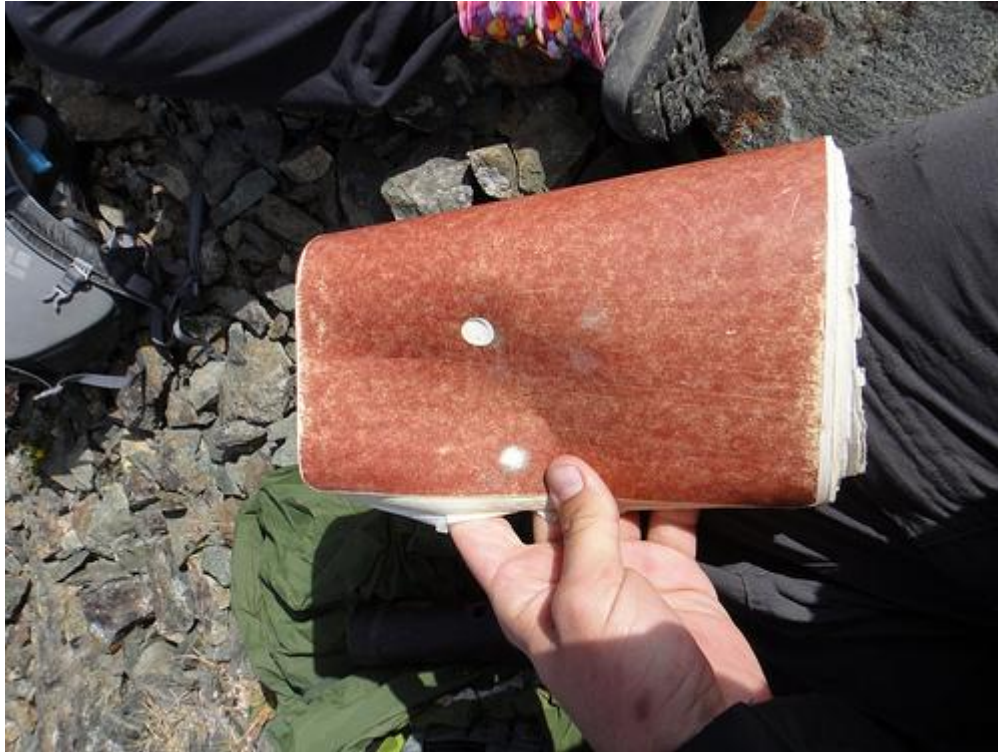
Up top we found one of the more interesting registers I've come across. The container was a damn heavy metal pipe with a screw top that had apparently originally been located over on Belial. Inside we found the Devil's Throne register which surprisingly went back all the way to 1963 and wasn't half full.



It now has some historic teeth marks as well.



At some point lightning had hit the container melting a hole through the pipe. Looking at the hole we were both amazed the register hadn't been incinerated but it had only burned a hole through the last ten pages or so of the book.



The view from the Throne was awesome.

We reversed our path taking a shortcut down some ledges back into the bowl and then back along the ridge to Belial. (Note, shortcut is actually a mountaineering term meaning “God I hope this doesn’t cliff out”)

We were both running out of water as we traversed around the back and over the top of Belial. That nondescript puddle below the He / She saddle started to be something we were looking forward to quite a bit. We pooled what water we had and still reached it rather thirsty.

As it turned out the puddle was infested with little red swimmers. They were unavoidable as we filled our bottles but it's amazing how little you care when you're really thirsty.

Bolstered by water and little red swimmers we marched up the saddle again.



Tricia beat me back to the crest where she waited behind a rock to get out of the now chilly wind. The temperature was dropping and we'd been warned by one of the climbers on Belial that the weather was set to take a turn for the worse the next day.

We were in camp before dark and spent a rather pleasant evening making dinner and looking up at an absolutely clear sky. I think we made it to bed around 11:30 pm as a slight haze was blowing in.

Day 2: Cold Traverse From the Devils to the Tower



We woke up at dawn to howling wind and frost sitting in my Crocs outside the tent. After some consideration we made extra coffee and hung around camp until 9 am hoping for the clouds masking the peaks above to retreat.



After that failed to happen we started up the chute around 9 am.



We were hoping the weather would improve by the time we reached the He / She saddle but sadly that proved to be overly optimistic.

He Devil from this side was a 3rd class route described inconsistently in the local peak guides. Not wanting to get stuck up on wet or icy rocks we decided to wait and see what the weather was going to do.



We sat on the ridge and watched clouds swirl over the summit of He Devil leaving behind frosted trees and rocks while even less promising clouds approached.



It was a somewhat frigid wait but we made the best of the situation and kept an eye on the peak. (Best of the situation being a mountaineering term for “freezing our collecting keesters off”)



Finally we had a few spots of blue sky appear above us and we went for it.

The approach from the saddle starts gets interesting at two short 3rd class cracks. The climbing wasn't bad except for the chockstone sitting in the first one.





I went over it very gingerly doing my best not to weight the thing and not feeling great about the move I had to pull. The rock was solidly placed but the fact it wasn't connected with the rock and vibrated when you smacked it made both Tricia and I a bit nervous.

The wind was damn cold and hitting us rather relentlessly to the point where Tricia was losing feeling in her hands and feet. The combination of the chockstone and the cold made her decide to wait at the saddle while I continued up.



The climb was adventurous, maybe a bit too much so. On the way up I did some climbing that strayed into 4th class (fall = coffin.) Granted this is only a problem if you fall.

I continued up gingerly traversing around the north side of a small subpeak and then climbing the south of the peak from a loose-ish chute.



I reached the frost coated trees which were actually rather striking looking. Ice on the rocks was minimal and the clouds had retreated for the time being.



Up top I found the summit cairn coated in small frost nodules.



I signed in, took some pictures, and then did a somewhat hairy traverse to the slightly lower pinnacle nearby to see if it was more interesting. It wasn't but it gave me a good shot of the summit cairn.



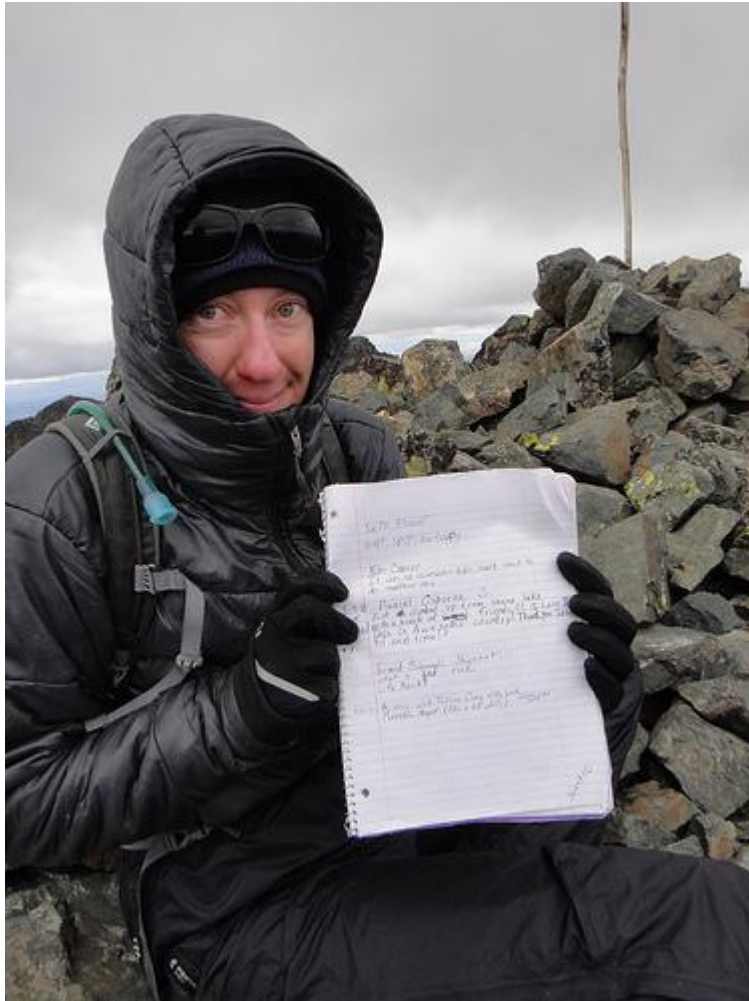


Now I had to down climb and I wasn't overly looking forward to going back down that 4th class section. Fortunately (I suppose) it turns out there's a more obvious easy 3rd route I'd missed. A bit less exciting but it got me down in one piece. I eased over the questionable chockstone one more time and met a rather chilly Tricia down below.

The weather wasn't improving as much as we'd have liked but we'd hauled our butts out of our warm sleeping bags and climbed up all that way so we set off west along the ridge towards She Devil.



Compared with He Devil She Devil was an easy scramble. Soon we were up top.



"A very cold Tricia Clay was here. Matthew Hengst (also a bit chilly)"

I had a grand plan to traverse the ridge from He Devil all the way to Tower of Babel. Tricia decided on account of being frozen and lacking feeling in some rather important appendages it was best she return to camp but she encouraged me to go ahead with my plan.



I set off solo planning just to head down a little ways and take a look. Once I was moving however it seemed too much of a hassle to turn around.



The route I took can be seen in this following panorama I took from the summit of The Ogre Monday.



I tagged Mt Baal along the way, rather nondescript as advertised and barely enough of a standalone bump to get an unofficial name. There was a register but it was only a few years old, same as the rest of the peaks on the crest as they were very commonly climbed.

The scramble up Tower of Babel proved to be the most interesting part of the day. The peak guide was somewhat less than useful and I ended up just making something work.



Looking back from where I came.



Plenty of interesting 3rd class to play around on.



A section of the Marshal Ledge system route the location and description of which seemed to vary between each trip report I'd read.



I made the summit and found another recently placed register sitting in a thermos.



I was reluctant to do any backtracking so I tried to descend the far side where I would eventually meet up with the Goat Trail route which I could use to descend back to Sheep Lake.

It started out questionable and quickly proceeded to nasty 4th+ class climbing. I went down two ledges, teeth gritted the entire time keeping a death grip on the rock. Looking down at how many more I'd have to do and seeing there was at least one section that I couldn't even tell if it was passable I decided this wasn't such a good idea. Later I found someone who had climbed the route with a rope and claimed it was a 5.6.

I climbed back up to the summit and headed back the way I came. I knew there was a well defined descent if I backtracked all the way back to the far side of Baal but didn't really want to hoof it back that far. Instead I picked a closer chute that looked promising and headed down.



It was interesting. (Mountaineering term for "Gee I'm glad I lived.")



Eventually I made it down to the lake near where we had exited the Goat Trail. All of the tents from the day before save one had left. Must have been the weather?



I returned to camp to find a rather warm and happy Tricia laying inside her sleeping bag with a hot drink at the ready.

We turned in much earlier that night mostly on account of how unpleasant it was outside of the tent on account of the temperature dropping. We both went to bed wearing most of our layers listening to the wind.

Day3: Sunlight Returns and Traversing The Goblin To The Ogre



I looked out the tent the next morning to a rather improved weather situation. The wind was painfully cold but had died down somewhat.



I think Tricia is in there somewhere...



There was frost on the tent and some of our water had frozen.

The original plan had been to hop over the crest one more time in order to pick up two rocky peaks off on their own called The Goblin and The Ogre.

The sun came out and the weather looked to be better than the previous day so Tricia and I set out.



Rather than climb the same chute again we went over and tried the climb between Baal and She Devil. From the top it hadn't looked to bad but it turned out to be much more annoying than our chute. Live and learn.



We reached the crest and descended the far side towards Upper Cannon Lake.



We could see our peaks now. There wasn't much information on The Goblin (left peak) but I wanted to try to climb the far left side and traverse over the two peaks. Tricia was still feeling the effects of freezing the previous day and elected to meet me on Ogre by coming up the right slope.





Upper Cannon was a beautiful lake I'd love to camp at sometime. There was even a nice place to jump into the deep water from a cliff.

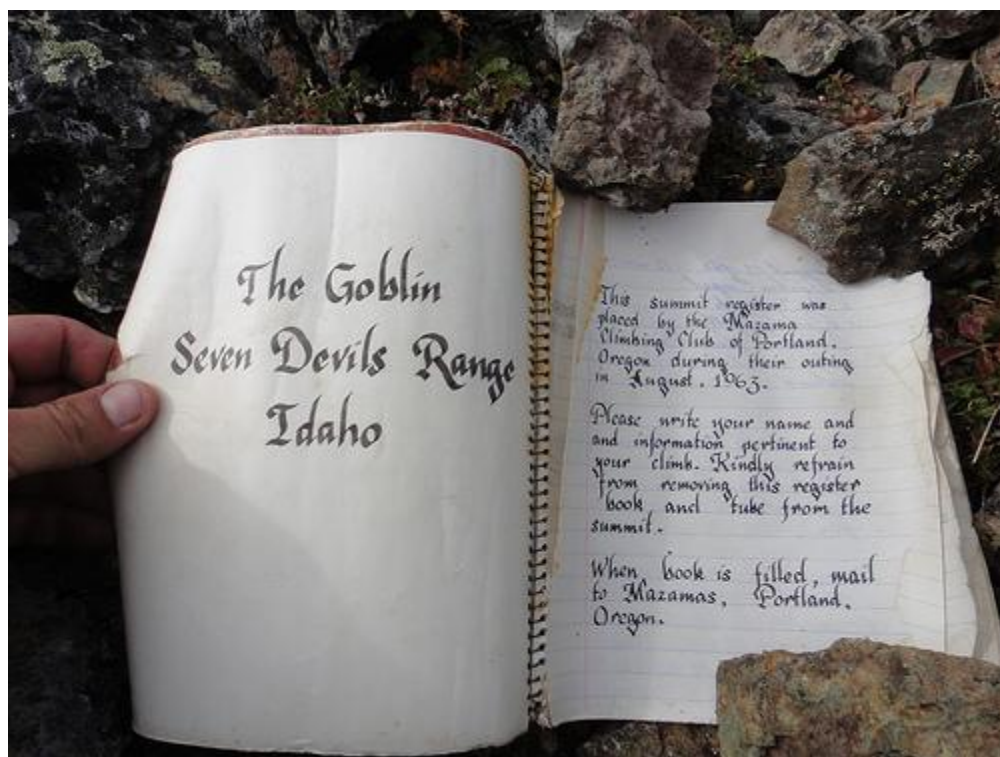
The easy route up the Goblin was to the southwest which was pretty much opposite of where I was coming up. I had an interesting time.



I ended up traversing around the backside, easing my way over some rather precarious chutes and climbing up a steep extended slab.



I was quite glad when I found a way to the top.



Another 1963 Mazamas register was waiting for me. No lightning holes in the container though.

Now I just had to traverse over to the Ogre to meet Tricia.



The down climb on the west side of The Goblin was a disappointment after the adventurous climb up. I strolled across the saddle and started up The Ogre. According to the peak guide I'd find an unclimbable section where I'd need to traverse out on the face to pick up a gully.

Never found it. Unclimbable my half broken rear end.



I found Tricia waiting for me as I scrambled up the last few rocks to the summit.





The Ogre was climbed quite often by the easy west ridge and the original 1963 register was long filled and removed.



As always Devil's Throne was the most striking peak visible.



We descended the west ridge of The Ogre and climbed the He Devil / She Devil saddle again and descended the overly familiar chute for the last time.



We were back in camp and packed up by 4. It had warmed up significantly to the point Tricia was back down to only a single layer. I hadn't expected that after the previous day.



It really was a beautiful day and we both remarked on what a shame it was to leave but we both had places to be the following day.



After looking over the options Tricia and I decided to take the long 9 mile trail back to the parking lot rather than the 1.5 mile Goat Trail in order to see some new scenery.





We made the car a bit before 8 pm as the temperature was really starting to drop again.

Sometime around 11:30 pm we rolled back into Boise and ate at the one oddball Mexican food place open at 11:30 pm on Labor Day. Hurray for mystery meat burritos!

We crashed at the rental house and after a rather paltry 3 hours of sleep we rolled out of bed and I drove Tricia to the airport to catch her flight.

Despite the cold weather this had been one of the smoother trips I'd been on of late. Both Tricia and I moved at about the same speed and didn't require much in the way of breaks and both just enjoyed the heck out of being out there.